

INTRODUCTION TO THEOLOGY

Part One: The Foundations

At the Burning Bush

Morning Star Regional Seminary, Barrackpore | BTh First Year | Student Edition

A Word Before We Begin

These notes take a different road to a familiar destination. The standard road walks through definitions, then branches, then faith and revelation, one block after another. The road taken here begins instead at a single place and refuses to leave it: the mountain of Horeb, where a shepherd named Moses turned aside to see a bush that burned and was not consumed (Ex 3:1-6). The claim of these notes is simple. Everything that an introduction to theology must say about the nature, the task, the language, the definitions, and the foundations of theology is already present, in seed, in that one chapter of Exodus. Each unit of Part One therefore returns to Horeb from a new angle, so that by the end the student does not merely possess a list of concepts but inhabits a single scene that holds the concepts together.¹

Why a single image rather than a syllabus of separate topics? Because the mind holds a story better than it holds a list, and because theology itself, as we shall see, is not first a list of doctrines but the articulation of an encounter. The bush burns; Moses turns aside; a voice speaks; a name is given; a mission is entrusted. That sequence, encounter, attention, word, name, mission, is the sequence of theology itself. When you forget a definition during the oral examination, walk back to the mountain. The definition will be waiting there.

Pope Francis, in his 2023 *motu proprio Ad Theologiam Promovendam*, asked for exactly this kind of turn: a theology that is fundamentally contextual, born from listening, done on the knees, and in dialogue with cultures and the poor.² These notes attempt to honour that call while remaining faithful to the classical tradition of Anselm, Aquinas, and the Second Vatican Council. Faithfulness and freshness are not rivals; they are the two hands of the same craft.

Unit 1. The Bush That Burns: What Theology Is

1.1 A Burning Question to Open the Unit

Here is the question with which everything begins, and to which we shall return at the close of Part One: why did Moses turn aside? He was at work. The flock of Jethro needed watching. Bushes catch fire in the desert often enough. Yet the text says, with quiet insistence, that Moses said, I will turn aside and see this great sight, why the bush is not burnt (Ex 3:3, RSV-2CE). Theology begins in that turning aside. It begins whenever a human being interrupts the ordinary economy of work and survival because something in reality glows with a strangeness that will not be explained away. A person who never turns aside never theologises. A person who turns aside has already begun.

¹The reading of Exodus 3 as a compressed map of the theological task follows the classroom practice at MSRS, Barrackpore, where the six definitions of theology are keyed to six moments of the chapter. See the course outline for ST 01, Introduction to Theology, Morning Star Regional Seminary-Barrackpore.

²Francis, *Ad Theologiam Promovendam*, apostolic letter *motu proprio*, 1 November 2023, nos. 4-8.

EXAMPLE: A tea seller at Barrackpore railway station watches thousands of commuters pass each morning. One monsoon evening he notices an old woman sheltering a stray dog under her only umbrella while she herself gets soaked. He cannot stop thinking about it. Why did she do that? What kind of world makes such an act possible, and what kind of heart? Without knowing the word, he has turned aside. The bush has burned for him. Theology is what happens when such turning aside becomes disciplined, communal, and sustained reflection in the light of faith.

The word theology itself is older than Christianity. Plato and Aristotle used *theologia* for discourse about the gods.³ Etymologically it joins *theos* (God) and *logos* (word, reason, discourse): God-talk, the science of God. But Christians filled the old wineskin with new wine. For the Christian tradition, theology is not speculation about a distant deity; it is disciplined reflection on the God who has spoken and acted in human history, above all in Jesus Christ. Karl Rahner puts the whole of it in one sentence: the only really absolute mysteries in Christianity are the self-communication of God in the depths of existence, which we call grace, and in history, which we call Christ.⁴

1.2 Six Flames from One Bush: The Definitions Mapped onto Exodus 3

Most textbooks list the definitions of theology as though they were rival products on a shelf. The approach here is different. The six great definitions are six flames of the one bush, six moments of the one encounter narrated in Exodus 3. Read the chapter with these notes open beside it and watch each definition rise out of the text.

- 1) **First, faith seeking understanding.** Moses sees the bush and asks why it is not consumed (Ex 3:3). The question is intellectual before it is anything else. This is the definition of Saint Anselm of Canterbury, *fides quaerens intellectum*, coined in the Proslogion: I do not seek to understand in order that I may believe, but I believe in order that I may understand.⁵ The seeking in the middle of the phrase does real work. It guards against two ditches on either side of the road: fideism, which accepts everything revealed without any scrutiny by reason, and rationalism, which rejects everything that reason cannot fully master. Theology walks the ridge between them, believing and questioning at once.
- 2) **Second, faith seeking love.** The bush burns with fire, and fire in the mystical tradition is the sign of love (Ex 3:2). Augustine confesses that he came late to loving the Beauty ever ancient, ever new, and his entire theological labour flows from that love.⁶ The famous legend of Augustine and the child at the seashore, attempting to pour the ocean of the Trinity into a small hole in the sand, teaches the same lesson from the other side: the intellect alone cannot contain what only love can approach. Theology without love hardens into ideology; love without theology softens into sentiment.
- 3) **Third, faith seeking justice.** The voice from the bush says: I have seen the affliction of my people who are in Egypt, and have heard their cry because of their taskmasters; I know their sufferings (Ex 3:7). Then, without pause, the seeing God sends a human being: Come, I will send you to Pharaoh (Ex 3:10). Gustavo Gutierrez distilled this into the classic definition of liberation theology: theology is a reflection on Christian praxis in the light of the Word.⁷ In

³Aristotle, *Metaphysics* 6.1, 1026a19, where *theologike* names the highest of the theoretical sciences. See Frederick Copleston, *A History of Philosophy*, vol. 1 (New York: Doubleday, 1993), 287-289.

⁴Karl Rahner, *Foundations of Christian Faith: An Introduction to the Idea of Christianity*, trans. William V. Dych (New York: Crossroad, 1978), 12.

⁵Anselm of Canterbury, *Proslogion*, in *Anselm of Canterbury: The Major Works*, ed. Brian Davies and G. R. Evans (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998), 87 (*Proslogion* 1).

⁶Augustine, *Confessions* 10.27, trans. Henry Chadwick (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1991), 201.

⁷Gustavo Gutierrez, *A Theology of Liberation: History, Politics, and Salvation*, rev. ed., trans. Caridad Inda and John Eagleson (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1988), 11.

India, George Soares-Prabhu heard the same cry rising from Dalits, Adivasis, women, and the wounded earth, and insisted that the cry for life is the locus where God speaks today.⁸

- 4) **Fourth, faith seeking ritual expression.** Come no closer, says the voice; remove the sandals from your feet, for the place on which you are standing is holy ground (Ex 3:5). Before Moses receives a message he receives a ritual. Worship precedes mission. This is why liturgy and sacraments are not decorations added to theology but one of its native languages. The Church prays before she defines, and her oldest rule states that the law of prayer grounds the law of belief.
- 5) **Fifth, faith seeking dialogue.** Moses is sent to speak both to Pharaoh, the ruler (Ex 3:10), and to the elders of Israel, the people (Ex 3:16-18). Theology must find words for the palace and words for the tent, words for power and words for the poor, words for the believer and words for the sceptic. In the Indian setting this becomes dialogue with the great religious traditions, with secular thought, and with the subaltern communities whose voices the palace rarely hears.
- 6) **Sixth, faith seeking harmony.** The promise from the bush points to a land flowing with milk and honey (Ex 3:17), an image not of escape from the world but of a healed creation in which land, animals, and people flourish together. Ecological theology and the theologies of cosmic reconciliation grow from this flame. Faith seeks not only true statements and just structures but a reconciled cosmos.

Gather the six flames and one sees why the tradition adds still further phrasings: faith seeking interiority (spiritual theology), faith seeking integrity or wholeness (eschatology), and, in the repeated theme of Pope Francis, faith seeking joy. His major documents form a litany of gladness: the joy of the Gospel, the joy of love, the joy of truth, rejoice and be glad.

INDIAN CONTEXT: The bush burns and is not consumed. India knows this grammar well. The Upanishadic seers spoke of the Real that blazes within all things without being exhausted by them, and the Rig Veda already taught that the One Being is spoken of by the wise in many ways: *ekam sat vipra bahudha vadanti*. A seminarian in Bengal does not import the question of God into a godless land; he steps into a civilisation that has turned aside toward burning bushes for three thousand years. The task is to bring the flame of Horeb into conversation with the flames already lit, and to hear, with Soares-Prabhu, the cry of the afflicted that rises from the brick kilns of North 24 Parganas as surely as it once rose from Egypt.

1.3 What Theology Is Not

Clearing the ground matters as much as building on it. Theology is not brainwashing, since it lives by questions rather than by their suppression. It is not an adult catechism, since catechesis hands on settled formulations while theology also probes, tests, and reformulates. It is not merely an exhaustive knowledge of Christian doctrines, since a person may memorise the entire **Denzinger** (Heinrich Joseph Dominicus Denzinger (1819-1883) was a German Catholic priest and theologian. He is famous because, in **1854**, he published a collection of the most important official teachings of the Catholic Church. The book became so well known that theologians simply call it **Denzinger**.) and never once have turned aside. The movement of theological formation runs deeper: information becomes formation, and formation opens into transformation. The measure of a theology course is not how much the student can repeat but how differently the student sees, loves, and acts.

Blaise Pascal marked the inner boundary of the discipline in a sentence every theologian should carry: the heart has its reasons, which reason does not know.⁹ Yet Pascal was a mathematician, and his point is not an invitation to abandon rigour. The reflections of the theologian must be rational, or better,

⁸George M. Soares-Prabhu, "The Dharma of Jesus: An Interpretation of the Sermon on the Mount," in *Collected Writings of George M. Soares-Prabhu*, vol. 4 (Pune: Jnana-Deepa Vidyapeeth, 2001), 223-251.

⁹Blaise Pascal, *Pensees*, trans. A. J. Krailsheimer (London: Penguin, 1995), no. 423.

reasonable: the mind reaching toward truth while carried by all the human faculties, memory and desire and imagination included. The First Letter of Peter states the public duty plainly: always be prepared to make a defence to any one who calls you to account for the hope that is in you, yet do it with gentleness and reverence (1 Pet 3:15).

A NOTE FOR THE CLASSROOM: Older manuals sometimes presented theology as a deductive science that begins from defined dogmas and derives conclusions, on the model of geometry. Contemporary scholarship, including the International Theological Commission in its 2012 document *Theology Today*, presents a richer picture: theology arises from listening to the Word of God, lives within the communion of the Church, and aims at wisdom, not only at correct deduction. Both accounts value rigour; the newer account restores the primacy of the living Word over the syllogism.

1.4 Faith as the Condition of Possibility

Can one do theology without faith? A scholar of religion can study Christian texts, and such study has genuine value; but the study of religion observes the bush from a distance, while theology removes its sandals. Faith is the condition for the possibility of theology because theology is faith itself, become reflective. Bernard Lonergan states it with precision: theology mediates between a cultural matrix and the significance and role of a religion within that matrix.¹⁰ The mediation only works if the mediator stands inside the faith being mediated. One can describe fire from a laboratory report; one can also speak from within the burning. Theology speaks from within.

This is why the tradition insists that theology is done with an open mind, on the knees, and with a magnanimous heart. The theologian satisfied with a complete and conclusive thought has stopped too soon. *Veritatis Gaudium* calls the good theologian to an open, incomplete thought, always turned toward the maius, the ever-greater, of God and of truth.

1.5 Review Questions for Unit 1

- Why does the sequence of Exodus 3 (encounter, attention, word, name, mission) serve as a map of the theological task? Illustrate with two of the six definitions.
- Distinguish theology from catechesis and from religious studies, using the image of the sandals.
- How does the middle term seeking in *fides quaerens intellectum* guard against both fideism and rationalism?
- In what sense is faith the condition for the possibility of theology? May a person without faith contribute anything to theology? Argue both sides.

Unit 2. Speaking from the Fire: The God-Question and Theological Language

2.1 The Burning Question

Moses hides his face, for he is afraid to look at God (Ex 3:6). Yet within moments he is asking God for a name (Ex 3:13). Fear and speech, silence and question, stand side by side in the same scene. That tension is the entire problem of theological language in miniature. Can creatures speak of the Creator at all? And if they can, how do their small words carry so great a freight? This unit answers in three steps: the question of the existence of God, the two paths of theological assertion, and the doctrine of analogy that holds the paths together.

2.2 Three Postures Before the Bush

Humanity has taken **three basic postures** before the mystery.

¹⁰Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1971), xi.

The **atheistic posture** rejects the existence of God; its most searching modern representatives, **Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud**, are rightly called the **masters of suspicion**, since each unmasked religion as a projection of something else: economic alienation, resentment, or infantile wish.¹¹ The **agnostic posture** suspends judgement: one does not and perhaps cannot know. The **theistic posture** affirms a personal God, origin of the universe and of humankind. The First Vatican Council, in *Dei Filius*, and the Second, in *Dei Verbum*, both teach that God, the first principle and last end of all things, can be known with certainty from created reality by the natural light of human reason.¹²

Two remarks keep this teaching honest. **First**, the Church claims that God can be known by reason, not that every individual will in fact reach that knowledge unaided; sin, suffering, and circumstance cloud the mind. **Second**, the masters of suspicion deserve gratitude as well as rebuttal. Their objections burn away idols. A god who is merely the projection of my economic interest or my fear of death ought to be rejected, and the God of the burning bush is precisely not that god, since he arrives unbidden, disturbs comfort, and sends the frightened shepherd toward Pharaoh rather than away from him.

EXAMPLE: Test the psychological projection theory against Exodus 3 itself. If Moses had invented a god to serve his wishes, the invention would have promised him safety in Midian, where he had a wife, a flock, and no warrant for his arrest. Instead, the voice sends him back to the country where he is a wanted man, to confront the most powerful ruler on earth. A projection consoles; this presence commands. The difference between the two is one of the oldest arguments for the reality of revelation.

2.3 Two Paths up the Mountain: Apophatic and Cataphatic

Theological assertion moves along a dual path. The apophatic or negative way insists on the inadequacy of every description of the absolute mystery; its Indian form is the celebrated *neti neti*, not this, not this, of the Brhadaranyaka Upanisad,¹³ and its Spanish Carmelite form is the *nada, nada* of John of the Cross. The cataphatic or positive way affirms that God has genuinely revealed himself and therefore predicates may be posited: Father, Shepherd, King, Judge, Rock, Light. Scripture itself walks both paths. God is invisible (Rom 1:20; Col 1:15), incomprehensible (Ps 139:6; Job 36:26), dwelling in unapproachable light (1 Tim 6:16); and yet Scripture never stops naming him, page after page, image upon image.

The **medieval** mystical treatise *The Cloud of Unknowing* (14th-century Christian mystical work. It teaches that **God cannot be fully known by human reason or intellectual effort. The famous line: "By love he may be gotten and holden, but by thought never."**) presses the negative way to its limit: by love he may be gotten and holden, but by thought never.¹⁴ (Meaning: We cannot grasp God completely by thinking, studying, or reasoning alone. We come into communion with God through love, prayer, and contemplation. Love reaches where the intellect cannot.) The **Fourth Lateran Council** supplies the rule that disciplines both paths: between Creator and creature no similarity can be affirmed without a greater dissimilarity being affirmed.¹⁵ Every image we make of God is more unlike God than like God. The bush gives the same lesson in narrative form: the fire is truly seen, yet the bush is not consumed; God truly appears yet is not captured by the appearing.

2.4 Analogy: The Grammar of the Middle Way

¹¹The phrase masters of suspicion originates with Paul Ricoeur, *Freud and Philosophy: An Essay on Interpretation*, trans. Denis Savage (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1970), 32-35.

¹²First Vatican Council, *Dei Filius*, chap. 2; Second Vatican Council, *Dei Verbum*, no. 6, in *The Documents of Vatican II*, ed. Walter M. Abbott (New York: Guild Press, 1966).

¹³Brhadaranyaka Upanisad 2.3.6, in *The Principal Upanisads*, ed. and trans. S. Radhakrishnan (London: George Allen and Unwin, 1953), 194.

¹⁴*The Cloud of Unknowing*, ed. Patrick J. Gallacher (Kalamazoo, MI: Medieval Institute Publications, 1997), chap. 6.

¹⁵Fourth Lateran Council (1215), constitution 2, in Norman P. Tanner, ed., *Decrees of the Ecumenical Councils*, vol. 1 (London: Sheed and Ward, 1990), 232.

How then can we speak at all? Thomas Aquinas answered with the doctrine of analogy, and the distinction is worth mastering because it will serve you in every later course. A term is univocal when it carries one identical meaning across its uses: six, mango, horse. A term is equivocal when the same sound names entirely different things: bank of a river and bank of money, ring on a finger and ring of a bell, trunk of an elephant, trunk of a car. A term is analogical when it applies to different realities in a way partly the same and partly different, ordered by a real relation between them.¹⁶ When we call God Father, the word is neither univocal (God is not male, not biological, not one father among fathers) nor equivocal (the word is not empty noise); it is analogical, because creation really participates in and reflects its Creator, so that from the created order something of God can truly be known and truly be said.

Analogy is therefore not a defeat of language but its consecration. Creation is the outpoured love of God; it carries the rays of the divine perfection and beauty the way a bush carries flame without being destroyed. Our words behave the same way. They burn with a meaning greater than themselves and are not consumed.

INDIAN CONTEXT: Indian religious thought offers theology a wealth of reflection on sacred language. The Mimamsa school analysed the eternity of the Vedic word; the grammarian Bhartrhari taught that all reality is disclosed in sabda, the word; and Sanskrit poetics developed the doctrine of dhvani, suggestion, by which a poem means more than it states. Soares-Prabhu drew on dhvani to argue that the biblical text, like great poetry, evokes and transforms rather than merely informs.¹⁷ A Bengali student already knows this from Rabindranath Tagore, whose songs say God without ever exhausting God. Theological language in India need not begin from scratch; it begins from an inheritance.

2.5 God-Experience: Where Language Is Born

Before theology speaks, something happens. Rudolf Otto named the happening: religious experience is the encounter with a mystery at once tremendous and fascinating, the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* that makes Moses hide his face and yet step closer.¹⁸ Scripture is a gallery of such encounters: the burning bush (Ex 3:2-6), the transfigured face brighter than the sun (Mt 17:1-13), the hearts burning within the disciples on the Emmaus road (Lk 24:13-35). The Bhagavad Gita places beside these the overwhelming vision of the cosmic form granted to Arjuna.¹⁹ In every case the experience outruns ordinary speech, and so theology uses ordinary language in an extraordinary way, stretching daily words, father, light, bread, way, until they carry the weight of glory.

Christian faith experience, however, adds something the general phenomenology of religion does not supply: history. God has acted in history through Jesus Christ; therefore the expression of faith cannot remain a private glow. It takes the fourfold public shape of the early community: koinonia, the communion of goods and hearts; diakonia, service; leitourgia, worship; martyria, witness unto death. Later generations added creeds and conciliar definitions, positive statements of faith in philosophical terms. The sequence matters: first the fire, then the community, then the formula. A formula remembered without the fire is ash.

A NOTE FOR THE CLASSROOM: Students sometimes hear the primacy of experience and conclude that doctrine is optional. Contemporary theology rejects that shortcut as firmly as it rejects dead formalism. George Lindbeck and others have shown that experience and language shape each other: the community and its creed teach us how to have the experience, just as the experience gives

¹⁶Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I, q. 13, a. 5, trans. Fathers of the English Dominican Province (New York: Benziger Brothers, 1948).

¹⁷George M. Soares-Prabhu, "Interpreting the Bible in India Today," in *Collected Writings of George M. Soares-Prabhu*, vol. 1 (Pune: Jnana-Deepa Vidyapeeth, 1999), 3-16.

¹⁸Rudolf Otto, *The Idea of the Holy*, trans. John W. Harvey (London: Oxford University Press, 1923), 12-40.

¹⁹Bhagavad Gita 11.9-14, in *The Bhagavadgita*, trans. S. Radhakrishnan (London: George Allen and Unwin, 1948), 271-274.

life to the creed. The burning bush and the removed sandals belong together; neither replaces the other.

2.6 Review Questions for Unit 2

- State the three postures before the God-question and explain why the masters of suspicion can serve theology even while opposing it.
- Define univocal, equivocal, and analogical predication with your own examples, and show why calling God Father is analogical.
- How does the rule of the Fourth Lateran Council discipline both the apophatic and the cataphatic ways?
- From your own life or from Indian literature, describe one experience that fits the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* of Otto, and reflect on the language you needed to describe it.

Unit 3. Naming the Fire: Definitions, Polarities, and the Branches of Theology

3.1 The Burning Question

Moses asks for a name and receives one that is also a refusal of every name: I AM WHO I AM (Ex 3:14). The name both reveals and reserves. So it is with the definitions of theology. Each true definition genuinely names the discipline; none exhausts it. This unit gathers the classical definitions into a working definition, then examines the seven polarities that every living theology must hold in tension, and closes with a map of the branches into which the one discipline unfolds.

3.2 A Chorus of Definitions

Set the voices side by side and listen for the harmony. The early Fathers understood theology as the study and interpretation of the Sacred Scriptures, so much so that for Origen theology and exegesis were nearly one craft.²⁰ Anselm gave the medieval West its watchword, faith seeking understanding. Gutierrez gave the twentieth century its counterweight, reflection on praxis in the light of the Word. Michael Amaladoss, writing from India, defines theology as the search of believers for an experiential understanding of God as relevant to transforming their lives in the world.²¹ Roger Haight widens the lens: Christian theology attempts to construe all things, the world, human existence, history, society, and God, within the vision mediated to the community by its religious symbols, Jesus, Eucharist, sacraments.²² And *Gaudium et Spes* supplies the hermeneutical charter: to read the signs of the times and interpret them in the light of the Gospel.²³

Braid the voices together and a working definition emerges. Christian theology is the systematic and disciplined interpretation of the meaning of human life and of reality as a whole in the light of the revelation given in Jesus Christ, and, in the same breath, the continual reinterpretation of Christian faith in the light of the new experiences and changing contexts of the world, carried out in and by the believing community. The definition moves in two directions at once, from revelation toward the world and from the world back toward revelation, and that double movement is called hermeneutics. Theology is hermeneutics or it is a museum.

EXAMPLE: Consider how a homily works. The preacher reads the Sunday Gospel (revelation toward the world) and also reads the week the parish has lived, a flood, an election, a death, a wedding (the world back toward revelation). A homily that only explains the text is a lecture; one that only

²⁰ *An Introduction to Theology* (Bangalore: Theological Publications in India, 2002), 8-9.

²¹ Michael Amaladoss, "Towards an Indian Theology," in *Theologizing in India*, ed. M. Amaladoss, T. K. John, and G. Gispert-Sauch (Bangalore: Theological Publications in India, 1981), 43-56.

²² Roger Haight, *Dynamics of Theology* (New York: Paulist Press, 1990), 1.

²³ Second Vatican Council, *Gaudium et Spes*, no. 4, in *The Documents of Vatican II*, ed. Walter M. Abbott (New York: Guild Press, 1966).

discusses the week is a newspaper. The genuine homily performs the double movement of the working definition in eight minutes. The whole of theology is that homily written large across centuries.

3.3 Seven Polarities: The Tensions That Keep Theology Alive

A bowstring shoots only while it is held in tension at both ends. Theology likewise lives by holding pairs of truths that pull against each other. Release either end and the discipline goes slack. There are seven such polarities.

- Mystery and intelligibility. Theologising is rational work and must be intelligible; yet it guards a mystery that no formulation exhausts. Lose the first and theology becomes fog; lose the second and it becomes a filing cabinet.
- Identity and change. The original faith-language of Scripture holds perennial value; yet it demands continual reinterpretation and reformulation. The Church of every age must say the same thing differently in order to say the same thing at all.
- Commitment and questioning. Theology is engaged, practical, and life-changing; at the same time it examines every belief, tradition, and practice in the light of contemporary knowledge. The theologian kneels and scrutinises, and does both sincerely.
- Community and the individual theologian. Faith is deposited and transmitted in a community, the locus theologicus; yet within the community the individual theologian may be called to a prophetic role, as Yves Congar was, silenced in the 1950s and vindicated at the Council he helped to shape.²⁴
- One and many. The core of Christian theology is the one Christ-event; yet the traditions are many, Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant, Pentecostal, and within Catholic theology itself the schools are many. The Vedic seers already knew the grammar: the One is spoken of by the wise in many ways.²⁵
- Universal and contextual. The theology of Thomas Aquinas was long presented as perennial theology for the entire Church; yet it too was a product of the thirteenth century, of Paris, of the arrival of Aristotle through Arab commentators. No theology floats free of history. All theologies are contextual, conditioned by historical, social, and cultural location; liberation, feminist, Black, Dalit, tribal, and ecological theologies simply make explicit what was always true.
- Orthodoxy and orthopraxis. Fidelity to the authentic faith (right belief) and commitment to right action that changes world and society belong together. The Letter of James arbitrates: faith by itself, if it has no works, is dead (Jas 2:17). Doctrines prove their coin in praxis; praxis keeps its direction from doctrine.

A NOTE FOR THE CLASSROOM: Older presentations sometimes ranked these pairs, treating the first member (mystery, identity, orthodoxy) as the truth and the second (intelligibility, change, orthopraxis) as a concession. The stronger contemporary account, visible in the 2012 International Theological Commission document *Theology Today* and in *Ad Theologiam Promovendam*, holds each pair as a genuine polarity: both poles are constitutive, and wisdom lies in the tension, not in the victory of one pole over the other.

²⁴Yves Congar, *True and False Reform in the Church*, trans. Paul Philibert (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 2011), first published in French in 1950.

²⁵Rig Veda 1.164.46.

3.4 One Fire, Seven Lamps: The Branches of Theology

From the one bush, light spreads into seven lamps. The branches of theology are not separate subjects that happen to share a corridor; they are angles of vision on a single discipline, distinguished by the aspect of the one revelation they serve. The table maps the field you will traverse over four years.

Branch	What it studies	Sample tracts
Fundamental theology	The foundations: revelation of the Triune God in Christ, its reception in faith, its credibility, its transmission and interpretation	Revelation, faith, credibility, Scripture and Tradition
Biblical theology	The Word of God in the Old and New Testaments, examined with valid interpretative tools; Scripture as the unique norm of the faith experience of the community	Pentateuch, Prophets, Wisdom, Gospels, Pauline letters, Revelation
Systematic (dogmatic) theology	Church doctrines reflected upon systematically and translated into language meaningful for the community	Trinity, Christology, pneumatology, ecclesiology, Mariology, grace, sacraments, eschatology
Moral theology and canon law	Christian morality on the basis of the revealed Word; laws that uphold morality and sustain commitment; in India both CIC and CCEO	Fundamental moral, bioethics, sexual ethics, marriage, social justice
Spiritual theology	Spirituality East and West, the mystics, the founders of religious congregations	History of spirituality, discernment, mysticism
Pastoral theology	The pastoral dimensions of Word, community, and worship	Catechetics, homiletics, counselling, liturgy in practice
Historical theology and missiology	The history of the Church and her mission; the Fathers; the development of dogma; Christianity in India; theology of religions, ecumenism, dialogue	Patrology, Indian Church history, mission, dialogue

The order of study is itself theological. Fundamental theology comes first because all theologising begins with faith and revelation; Scripture stands at the centre because, in the words of Dei Verbum, the study of the sacred page is the soul of sacred theology (DV 24); and pastoral theology crowns the sequence because the whole edifice exists so that a people may be shepherded.

INDIAN CONTEXT: Every branch, studied in India, passes through the lens of Indianness: Indian history, the analysis of Indian realities, the study of the subaltern communities and of the religions of India. Moral theology in India cannot bypass caste; ecclesiology cannot bypass the twenty-four Churches and the two Oriental Churches of our own soil, the Syro-Malabar and the Syro-Malankara; missiology cannot bypass three centuries of anti-conversion polemic and the present anxieties of religious minorities in Bengal and beyond. Justice and ecology are not optional seminars; they pervade every course, because the cry from the brick kilns and the cry from the drying rivers are, in the grammar of Exodus 3, one cry.

3.5 Formation of the Theologian: Four Stages, Four Dimensions

Because theology in a seminary forms persons and not only minds, the Church has articulated four stages of priestly formation, drawn from *Optatam Totius*, *Pastores Dabo Vobis*, and the *Ratio Fundamental Institutionis Sacerdotalis*: the propaedeutic stage (come and see), the discipleship stage (follow me), the configuration stage (remain in me), and the pastoral stage (go and tell).²⁶ Every stage carries four dimensions, human, spiritual, intellectual, and pastoral, and the theology you study belongs to the configuration stage: the years in which the seminarian is conformed to Christ the shepherd, leader, and teacher, so as to acquire, in the phrase of Pope Francis, the smell of the sheep.

Theology thus serves servant leadership in five registers: servant of the Word (configured to Christ, in persona Christi), servant of the word proclaimed (the prophet, descending mediation), servant of the servants (pastor, father, teacher), servant of the sacraments (priest, ascending mediation), and servant of the world (sign and instrument of the Kingdom of God). Keep the five registers before you during every examination and every pastoral weekend; they are why the examination and the weekend both matter.

3.6 Review Questions for Unit 3

- Construct the working definition of theology from at least three of the voices in the chorus (Anselm, Gutierrez, Amaladoss, Haight, Gaudium et Spes) and show the double hermeneutical movement within it.
- Choose two of the seven polarities and describe a concrete failure of theology that follows when one pole is released.
- Why is fundamental theology studied first, and in what sense is Scripture the soul of theology (DV 24)?
- How do the four stages and four dimensions of formation prevent theology from becoming a merely academic exercise?

Unit 4. The Voice and the Yes: Faith and Revelation, the Two Foundations

4.1 The Burning Question

Everything in Exodus 3 happens because God speaks first. Moses did not summon the bush; the bush summoned Moses. Yet nothing would have followed had Moses not answered, Here am I (Ex 3:4). Divine initiative and human response, voice and yes: these are the two foundations of theology, called in the tradition revelation and faith. This unit studies each foundation, then the bond between them, and closes where the whole of Part One has been pointing, at the Trinitarian centre of Christian revelation.

4.2 What Is Faith?

The Letter to the Hebrews gives the classical description: faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen (Heb 11:1). Two currents feed the biblical notion. In the Old Testament, faith is rooted in the fidelity of God to the divine promises and to the covenant with Israel; the Hebrew root *aman*, from which comes our *amen*, carries the sense of firmness, of leaning the whole weight of a life upon what holds. Abraham, who left Ur on the strength of a promise, is therefore the father of all who believe (Rom 4:3, 11). In the New Testament, faith is the acceptance of Jesus and his message, and afterwards of the apostolic preaching centred on the risen Lord; to believe in Christ is to entrust oneself to the events of his life, death, resurrection, and ascension.

²⁶Congregation for the Clergy, *Ratio Fundamental Institutionis Sacerdotalis*: The Gift of the Priestly Vocation (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 2016), nos. 57-79; John Paul II, *Pastores Dabo Vobis* (1992), nos. 42-59.

Two errors about faith must be cleared away. Faith is not merely an assent of the intellect to a set of truths, as though believing were the same as agreeing with a list. Nor is it a vague warmth without content. Faith is the total response and commitment of the whole person to God as revealed in Jesus Christ: intellect, will, affections, body, history. The encounters of Scripture display this wholeness. The Samaritan woman at the well leaves her water jar behind (Jn 4:28); the disciples at Emmaus turn back to Jerusalem that same hour (Lk 24:33); Moses walks toward Egypt. Faith moves feet.

EXAMPLE: Watch a Bengali grandmother at Bandel basilica. She may never have read a page of systematic theology, yet she has walked from Naihati, fasting, to keep a manat, a vow made when her grandson was ill. Ask her what faith is and she will not define it; she will point to the walking, the fasting, the candle, the vow kept. Hebrews 11 would recognise her at once, for its entire argument is a procession of people who did things: by faith Abel offered, by faith Noah built, by faith Abraham went out. Faith, in the Bible, is a verb wearing the clothes of a noun.

The models of faith in the New Testament are Mary, whose fiat at the Annunciation is the purest human echo of Here am I; Joseph, who obeys in silence; Zechariah and Elizabeth; the disciples with all their stumbling. Above them all stands Jesus himself, the model of faith par excellence: he entrusts himself to his Abba throughout his life, lives in unbroken communion with God, discerns the will of the Father through real struggle, in the desert and at Gethsemane, and remains faithful with a Yes that is total and irrevocable. The Letter to the Hebrews dares to call him the pioneer and perfecter of our faith (Heb 12:2). Our faith response is apprenticed to his.

4.3 What Is Revelation?

In his goodness and wisdom God chose to reveal himself and to make known to us the hidden purpose of his will, by which through Christ, the Word made flesh, we might in the Holy Spirit have access to the Father and come to share in the divine nature.
(Dei Verbum 2)

Revelation is the utterly gratuitous self-gift of God. Mark the noun: self-gift. Before the Second Vatican Council, manual theology often presented revelation chiefly as the communication of truths, a set of propositions delivered from heaven. Dei Verbum deepened the account without discarding it: what God reveals is first of all God, a person opening himself to persons, and the propositions are the faithful precipitate of that encounter.²⁷ Ephesians sings the plan in a single arc: with all wisdom and insight God has made known to us the mystery of his will, a plan for the fullness of time, to unite all things in him, things in heaven and things on earth (Eph 1:9-10).

God reveals through deeds and words intimately bound together. The deeds are the great events: creation, where God shows himself the author of life; the exodus, where God shows himself the liberator; the paschal mystery, where God shows himself the lover who gives everything; the Church, where God shows himself the God of a new people. The words interpret the deeds, and the deeds confirm the words. The burning bush again supplies the pattern: a deed is seen (the flame), a word is heard (I have seen the affliction of my people), and a name is given (I AM WHO I AM). Sight, speech, name: the anatomy of revelation.

The Letter to the Hebrews announces the climax: in many and various ways God spoke of old to our fathers by the prophets; but in these last days he has spoken to us by a Son (Heb 1:1-2). Jesus Christ is the fullness of revelation, the mediator who is at once God revealing and God revealed. With his resurrection and the sending of the Spirit, salvation history has entered its definitive period, and no new public revelation is to be awaited before the glorious manifestation of the Lord (DV 4; CCC 66). Yet closure of public revelation does not mean the silence of God. The Council affirms the presence and action of God in other cultures and religions (Nostra Aetate 2; Gaudium et Spes 22; Ad Gentes 7), for God desires all to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth (1 Tim 2:4). Revelation

²⁷On the shift from a propositional to a personalist model of revelation, see Avery Dulles, *Models of Revelation* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1992), 36-52; and Rene Latourelle, *Theology of Revelation* (New York: Alba House, 1966), 315-341.

is complete in Christ and still unfolding in comprehension: the Church, over the centuries, grows in understanding of what she has once for all received.

A NOTE FOR THE CLASSROOM: Older apologetics sometimes read the closure of revelation as a warrant for regarding other religions purely as human constructions awaiting replacement. The conciliar and postconciliar magisterium takes a more careful line: the fullness of revelation in Christ stands, and, at the same time, the seeds of the Word are present in the religions, so that dialogue and proclamation belong together rather than cancelling each other. The theology of religions course in a later year will map this terrain in detail; for now, hold both truths without amputating either.

4.4 The Bond: Revelation and Faith Need Each Other

Revelation and faith are inseparably united, as voice and answer, gift and reception. The object of faith is God, who can be known in this intimate way only because God unveils himself; and the self-unveiling of God reaches its goal only when a human being receives it. The Annunciation is the icon of the bond: the angel speaks, and heaven waits upon the fiat of a village girl (Lk 1:38). Revelation without faith is a letter never opened; faith without revelation is a letter never sent. Theology stands at the desk where the letter is opened, read, and answered.

Who receives revelation? Not an abstract intellect, but the human person who suffers, seeks life, meaning, and love, and who is open to a word from beyond. The conditions of possibility are the whole person: knowing, willing, acting. And the reception is never merely individual. Israel receives the exodus as a people; the Church receives the paschal mystery as a community gathered at Eucharist and Pentecost. The believing community is the visible carrier of the tradition of the foundational experience, which is why the community, and not the isolated scholar, is the home of theology.

4.5 The Centre: Trinity

Press the question of revelation to its centre and the centre opens as Trinity. The Christian experience of the Ultimate, articulated in the Bible as the self-disclosure of God as Father, Son, and Spirit, grounds the Trinitarian doctrine of the tradition. The evidence lies in prayer before it lies in dogma: Jesus cries Abba, Father (Mk 14:36), and the Spirit of the Son cries the same word in our hearts (Rom 8:15-16; Gal 4:6). We are drawn into a conversation that was going on before the world began. The Trinitarian mystery is therefore the source, the model, and the reference point of all human community: a communion of persons in whom difference does not divide and unity does not absorb.²⁸

INDIAN CONTEXT: India gives the Trinitarian centre a distinctive urgency and a distinctive resource. The urgency: a society graded by caste needs, more than most, the vision of a communion in which persons are equal without being identical, and the Trinitarian model of community stands as a standing judgement upon every hierarchy of birth. The resource: the Indian Christian tradition from Brahmabandhab Upadhyay onward has meditated on Saccidananda, being, consciousness, bliss, as a doorway through which Indian thought approaches the triune mystery. Upadhyay composed a Sanskrit hymn to the Trinity that seminarians in Bengal, his own homeland, should know by heart, for he shows that the deepest inculturation happens not at the level of vestments but at the level of the doctrine of God.

4.6 Review Questions for Unit 4

- Trace the movement from faith as assent to propositions toward faith as total personal response, using Hebrews 11, the Samaritan woman, and the fiat of Mary.
- In what sense is Jesus both the fullness of revelation and the model of faith? What follows for the seminarian from holding the two titles together?

²⁸For the recovery of the Trinity as the grammar of communion, see the survey in Catherine Mowry LaCugna, *God for Us: The Trinity and Christian Life* (San Francisco: Harper San Francisco, 1991), 1-18.

- Explain, with Dei Verbum 2 and 4, how public revelation can be closed while the understanding of revelation continues to grow.
- Why is the Trinity called the source, model, and reference point of human community, and what does that claim say to a caste-ordered society?

Closing the Circle: Back to the Mountain

Part One opened with a question: why did Moses turn aside? We may now answer it in the language we have acquired. He turned aside because reality glowed with mystery (Unit 1, the nature of theology); he hid his face and yet asked for a name because human words both fail and succeed before God (Unit 2, theological language); he received a name that reveals and reserves at once (Unit 3, definitions and polarities); and he answered a voice that had spoken first, with a Here am I that changed history (Unit 4, revelation and faith).

One question from the bush remains, and it is not addressed to Moses. Is the burning bush calling us? The Indian realities that surround this seminary, the migrant labourer, the Dalit Christian denied a place, the drying wetlands of the lower Ganga, the young person scrolling for meaning at two in the morning, burn without being consumed. Part Two of these notes will study the sources and the history of theology, the long record of how the Church has answered. But the record exists only because, in every generation, someone at work with a flock looked up, said I will turn aside and see, and then said Here am I. That is the whole curriculum. Everything else is footnotes.

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